



against South Africa, we only played one series against a Test-playing nation, the West Indies. In the last two years, we didn't receive the exposure and experience we expected after that performance," Paudel said.

"We've been playing matches, but not regularly against top teams. I'm not asking for six or seven series a year. Even one or two series annually against strong teams would help us test ourselves at that level."

It is a similar story for other Associate nations at this World Cup. The USA reached the Super Eights in its maiden T20 World Cup appearance in 2024 but did not face a

full-member side in a bilateral series afterwards.

In preparation for this tournament, the USA, The USA team, embroiled in a governance crisis, held a one-month camp in Sri Lanka, playing Sri Lanka A, Oman and two warm-up matches.

"If you look at our preparation for the World Cup, the reality is we hadn't played a T20 International since February last year," USA coach Pubudu Dassanayake said. "From that point onward, we didn't get any international T20 matches."

For most Associate nations, fixtures against Test-playing countries remain sporadic and, for

Stirring spell: Shadley van Schalkwyk's (centre) four for 25 tore through India's top order, reducing the host to 77 for 6 and pushing the USA to the brink of a famous upset before India recovered to prevail. GETTY IMAGES

teams like Canada and Oman, virtually non-existent outside multi-team events. The Netherlands was the only Associate side to travel outside its continent for a bilateral series against a full member, touring Bangladesh in September 2025 for three T20Is.

"We've probably punched above our weight over the years," the